I Feel Like I Don't Belong Here

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/50779207.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Post-Canon, Catra Needs a Hug (She-Ra), POV Catra (She-Ra), Angst, Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Fluff, Angst with a Happy Ending, Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Catra is Bad at Feelings (She-Ra)

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by higherfurtherfaster

Summary

Catra doesn’t get it.

She just doesn’t understand.

She tries, she really tries, but it doesn’t make sense, the fact that she isn’t in handcuffs and locked away in whatever constitutes a jail in Bright Moon.

(Catra struggles to understand the way she's being treated the night after defeating Horde Prime)

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Catra doesn’t get it.

She just *doesn’t* **understand**.

She tries, she really tries, but it doesn’t make sense, the fact that she isn’t in handcuffs and locked away in whatever constitutes a jail in Bright Moon.

Adora probably has something to do with it, since the fact that She-Ra says that she’s in love with her is likely enough to stop any random guard from tossing her in a cell, she assumes.

Even if she doubts the legitimacy of her current situation, she doesn’t doubt that Adora loves her. Because Adora is not only a terrible actor, but earnest to a fault, and she would never lie about that.

She probably knows that it would utterly shatter Catra if she did.

That’s the only reason she can come up with right now though. Even if her and Sparkles are friendly, she still killed her mom, and she should absolutely want her in jail for that alone. Plus, she threw Arrow Boy off a cliff, treated Scorpia like absolute dirt - Scorpia fits in at Bright Moon, and that makes Catra feel worse for a reason she can’t quite describe - as well as having sent Entrapta to Beast Island.

She’s done a lot of awful shit, and even if she’s working on being ‘redeemed’, as Adora’s put it, she’s still a bad person.

The only one who she feels like is treating her correctly is Mermista. She looks at her with such disdain and not so thinly veiled hatred, and it’s like a balm to Catra’s soul, almost. Because that look, that she understands.

It’s what she’s currently facing right now as she sits around the fire that’s been quickly erected - Sea Hawk’s doing, obviously - in Bright Moon’s courtyard. The whole place is worse for wear, although the only time that Catra’s really been here is when she laid siege to it - seriously, why is she not in jail? - so it’s not like she’s ever seen it in its best state.

Glimmer looked more than a little sad when they came back, and Bow had to comfort her, so it’s not hard for Catra to put two-and-two together, and to figure out that Horde Prime must have taken it over, or at the very least some bandits decided to ransack the place. It’s not been burnt to the ground like she did to Salineas though, so really it’s a net positive that it’s even still here.

What she’s largely focusing on though is Mermista. Mermista, who’s still glaring at her like she wants to burn Catra at the stake, which…..there’s probably more reasonable ways to kill her that she can come up with, just based on the fact that Mermista is a water princess, but regardless of the manner of death, there’s no argument that Mermista wants to end her life as slowly and as painfully as possible.

She’s pulled out of her thoughts by someone tapping her side, and she does her best not to flinch or bring her claws out. She’s only able to stop herself because she knows who it is, since she’s pressed against Adora’s side and she’s the only person who could have really touched her there given their positioning.

“Catra?”

Adora’s looking at her like she just asked her something, and it quickly morphs into concern once it’s clear that Catra doesn’t know what she said, or even who spoke to her.

“Glimmer was asking if you wanted the spare room to sleep in,” Adora explains, although there’s something in her eyes that Catra can’t quite place.

It’s hope, Catra thinks, but for what she isn’t quite sure.

“That the same spare room you used as a dungeon?” Catra smirks, and even if there’s a truthful part of her that is relieved that she’s going to end up there, there’s an ever bigger part of her that delights in the way that Sparkles’ eyes widen as she shakes her head.

“No! I mean, it was, but not anymore. Not since Shadow…..” she trails off, Adora’s wide eyes and shake of the head - which is not at all subtle - apparently making her rethink it. “We’re probably

gonna have to build a jail now, I guess, but that's not it. Anymore."

"Uh huh," Catra smirks, and Sparkles just audibly groans at the teasing, throwing her head back. "Whatever. I'll need a place to sleep, I guess, so I'll take it."

"Oh."

That's Adora, and Catra's brow furrows in confusion again as she looks up at her. Adora looks confused, and a little sad, and Catra isn't quite sure what prompted it. Especially since Adora was the one who brought it up.

Or maybe Sparkles did, but since Catra was too lost in her thoughts, she can't say for sure.

"I was kind of hoping that you'd share a bed with me. Like we used to," Adora explains, biting the inside of her cheek. She really is a terrible actor, with just how excited and hopeful she looks, and even if Catra knows that she's a bad person, she could never hurt Adora.

Not anymore, at least.

She feels like they should probably be past the point of sleeping at Adora's feet, but if Adora wants to fall back into that routine, she

can live with that.

It means she'll be close to Adora, and at the end of the day that's all she really wants. She knows that's probably pathetic, that she's willing to take whatever scraps Adora will give her, but she really doesn't care.

She's spent too long fighting how she really felt. Might as well embrace it, no matter how sad it makes her sound.

Everyone here either already hates her or should, so what's the harm in them thinking she's a pathetic lovesick fool too?

"If that's what you want," Catra reasons, because it also wouldn't be completely out of character for Adora to sacrifice her own comfort for Catra's feelings. She doesn't need to be a burden on the one person that apparently wants her here too, so better to be honest and put it all out in the open.

That's progress, right?

She's aware that she's picking and choosing about what she's being honest about and what she's telling Adora, but Perfuma'a always talking about taking things at her own pace, and making sure to not feel like she has to change so completely so suddenly.

She’s aware she’s just using bits and pieces of what Perfuma’s told her to rationalize the way she wants to behave. She’s not an idiot.

“Of course that’s what I want,” Adora grins, as overt and honest as ever, and it hits Catra deep in her gut, the fact that Adora’s being this open and she’s being this guarded. “Only if it’s what you want though. You don’t have to do anything you don’t want.”

“It’s….it’s what I want.”

“Is that, like, really a good idea?”

Adora looks so happy and about to say something no doubt sweet and loving to Catra, but Mermista pipes up before she can

“What….” Adora gets out, apparently more surprised than Catra, her eyes flitting around the fire before they fall on Mermista. “Why wouldn’t it be a good….”

“Um, in case she tries to murder you. Again.”

“Catra wouldn’t try to…..”

“ **Again.”**

“She’s not,” Adora argues, hand finding Catra’s and giving it a tight squeeze - Catra suspects its both for her benefit and to relay the point to Mermista - eyes flitting from Catra back to the other woman.

Catra can tell that Adora’s eyes are on her for a split second, but she doesn’t return it, gaze fully in her lap. She can’t look Adora in the eyes right now, can’t let her figure out what she’s really thinking.

That even if Catra doesn’t intend to hurt Adora ever again, based on her track record, Mermista’s not entirely wrong to worry about Catra being alone in a room with Adora.

If anything, Mermista’s in the right here.

She also would gladly have Catra’s head on a spike if she was given the chance, which is again, valid.

“Catra’s not going to hurt me.”

“Did you think that when you used to be friends too?”

“That’s not…that’s not fair,” Adora retorts, which honestly tells Catra all that she needs to know.

“Wildcat won’t hurt Adora,” Scorpia chimes in, and even if Catra knows that Scorpia means well - she always does - just hearing her vouch for her makes the pit in Catra’s stomach grow. Scorpia shouldn’t want to defend her, and if anything she should hate her as much as Mermista does.

Which only proves that Scorpia’s far too good of a person, and once again makes Catra feel like complete and utter shit due to the way that she used to treat her.

“Catra’s proven herself,” Glimmer backs her up as well, and it still freaks Catra out, the way that they’re defending her. Both because she’s not entirely sure she deserves it, but also because she needs to earn that support, and having to do that freaks her the fuck out.

Because what if she can’t? What if she turns bad again, or does something even more unforgivable and they kick her out of Bright Moon? What if Adora kicks her out of Bright Moon?

“To you, maybe,” Mermista argues back, Catra feeling Adora’s eyes on her the whole time. “She’s done jack shit to make up for what she did to me. Like, she can’t even defend herself right now!”

After that, it’s not just Adora’s eyes that Catra feels watching her.

“I um…I think that….I’m sor…..”

She tries to get the words out the best she can but they’re just *not* **coming out** . Once a fuckup, always a fuckup.

“I get it…I get….”

“Catra?” Adora asks beside her, hands in hers, and all Catra can see in front of her eyes are spots as she looks around. She hasn’t experienced something like this since they were kids, and she just can’t defend herself. All she wants is to get out of here and never look back.

She’s frozen though, until she can feel Adora getting her to her feet and saying *something* to the others there, before she’s being moved by Adora away from the fire and to where she does not know.

Catra doesn’t really find herself until she’s sat down on the fluffiest thing she’s ever felt.

“Catra? Can you hear me?”

It comes out muffled, like she's hearing Adora through shitty reception on Bow's trackerpad. The fact that it's Adora is still calming though, and before long, Catra finds herself taking deep breaths. Her vision clears, and she can hear clearly, and she's then faced with the most colourful surroundings that she's ever experienced.

"What the fuck……"

The first thing she sees is the waterfall, which is a) the worst place she can think of for showering, and b) very much not her aesthetic to have that much water that close to the bed.

The rest is just bright colour after bright colour, and once again, Catra's hit with the strong feeling that she just does not belong here.

The person she wants to be with does though, which only makes this more complicated.

"Hey there," she hears again, eyes flitting around before falling on the woman next to her on the bed. "I haven't seen that happen since we were kids."

Catra has to actively fight the urge to not let her claws come out and dig into her own palms as she's reminded of it.

In truth, Adora's not thinking of the last time that it happened, but the last time that she saw it happen. It's happened a handful of times since then, both when they were in the Horde together and after Adora left. Catra just better at hiding it.

She knows what time Adora's thinking about though.

It was when they were kids, Catra just old enough to no longer be considered a kitten. They were in training against the big kids - Catra suspects that Shadow Weaver wanted her to be put in her place in front of Adora - and Catra was paired against the top of the class for the bigger kids.

Suffice to say, she got the shit kicked out of her. In front of Adora, in front of Shadow Weaver, in front of everyone. It was humiliating and horrifying, but all she remembers is hearing Shadow Weaver talking to Adora about how this shows just how weak and useless Catra is.

She managed to get out of the training room without breaking down, but as soon as she got to her bed, she started freaking the fuck out. She remembers feeling like she couldn't breathe, but all she was doing was breathing, and she couldn't see and she couldn't hear and all she wanted was for it to stop.

It didn't though, not until Adora eventually came back, found her, and held her hand until she could think clearly.

She doesn't know much about them, but she knows enough now to know that it's a thing that happens to people, and isn't solely

something she experiences. She doesn't know what they're called though, or what they mean, she just knows that it's even more shit she has to deal with.

"Is this the first time it's happened since then?"

"Huh?"

"The….the scary breaths," Adora reiterates, that being what they named them when they were kids. "Is this the first time that it's happened since then?"

Catra doesn't say anything, just ducks her head, but that's enough for Adora.

"When was the last time you had one?"

"Can we not do this right now, Adora?"

"Catra….."

"I'm serious. Can we just….can we do this later. Please?"

Adora doesn't say anything, but the breath she lets out is enough for Catra to know that she's going to let it slide for now, even if they will have to talk about it in the future.

Just one of the many uncomfortable conversations that Catra's going to have to have in the next little bit.

"Don't listen to Mermista. She doesn't….she's just angry."

"About Salineas."

"Catra…."

"No, Adora," Catra sighs, getting to her feet and starting to pace, letting her claws run through what's left of her mane. "She's right to be pissed. She's the only one who's having a reasonable reaction to me being here!"

"Don't say that….."

"Just listen to me for a second," Catra snaps, instantly feeling that familiar pain in her chest at the wide hurt eyes she sees on Adora's face. "She's not wrong. I shouldn't be trusted to be in here with you, and I've given her no reason to think anything different. So just…maybe don't argue with her? Because she's right."

“No!” Adora vaults up from the bed, Catra almost jumping from how quickly she finds the blonde in front of her. “I’m going to defend you when other people say that you’re a bad person, because they’re wrong.”

“But I….”

“I know what you did,” Adora reiterates, and Catra can see her visibly take a breath before she continues. “I understand why Mermista is mad. I also understand that she doesn’t know you as well as I do, and that you’ll be mad at yourself far longer than she’s mad at you.”

“Adora…”

“It’s my turn to talk,” she smiles, and Catra can feel herself practically melt, because how the fuck did she actually manage to get this after all that she’s done?

“Can we lay some ground rules? Or suggestions?” she continues, and even though Catra can feel that feeling bubbling up again, she still nods her head, because who is she to say no to Adora? “When something like that happens, or you feel like it’s going to happen, could you come talk to me? Or get someone to come get me?”

“I…..I can try,” Catra gets out, because that’s really all she feels like she can do at this point.

“That’s all I want,” Adora smiles wide, and in that moment, there’s no doubt in Catra’s mind that she’s telling the truth. “And can I ask one more thing? Just one?”

“Whatever you want.”

“You sweetheart,” Adora giggles, cheeks flushing, and Catra can’t keep down her own blush as she ducks her head. “I just want you to talk to me if you’re ever feeling bad. Which I know…I know it happens a lot, but if it’s ever really bad, could you just come and find me. You’re more important to me than whatever I’d be doing. No question.”

“She-Ra choosing me over Etheria?” Catra teases, Adora’s obvious love making her feel just a little bit like herself again. “I’ll keep that to myself. Wouldn’t want it getting out.”

“We wouldn’t, would we,” Adora giggles again, stepping closer, and Catra can feel her eyes wanting to flutter shut as Adora leans in. “Is this okay?”

“Yeah,” Catra breathes out the second before their lips connect, and despite all of her misgivings and concerns, in that moment, Catra knows that there’s no place else she’d rather be.

"We'll find you clothes that fit your tail in the morning," Adora comments, biting the inside of her cheek as she looks at the sleep pants in her hands. Catra can see the gears turning in there, Adora thinking about how to please other people, like always, but she doesn't need to right now.

"It's okay," she shrugs, gesturing at the shirt in her hand. "I can just use this. It's big enough."

"Yeah…yeah okay. We will find you stuff to wear tomorrow though!"

"Should I be worried that you want me to wear clothes so much?" Catra retorts, knowing it'll get a rise. And, true to what she expected, Adora turns bright red, sputtering out something that Catra thinks is meant to be a defense and protecting Catra's modesty.

"Shut up," Adora eventually relents, and Catra just rolls her eyes, walking past her girlfriend and into the bathroom to change.

She's changed in front of Adora before - there's no modesty in the Fright Zone with how cramped they were - but it feels different now, with them being what they are, so she figures that, until

they truly know what they are now, that it's probably safer to change in the bathroom.

Although considering she won't have any pants on, modesty probably isn't all that important.

Regardless, Catra quickly changes and comes back out a minute later, Adora already having changed as well and sitting on the bed. She's sitting up far straighter than Catra things can be comfortable, and she can practically hear the gears turning in that blonde head of hers.

"Everything good?" She can't help asking, because she feels like shit has to hit the fan at some point. Adora's probably realized that Catra sleeping in here with her is a mistake, and she's trying to figure out a way to explain that Catra should actually be in a cell, and not in here with her.

"Yeah! Yeah everything's great!"

Okay, that's entirely too forced.

"Just….you're here," Adora continues, and *okay* , that's not what Catra was expecting. "I just can't believe you're here."

"Well, believe it. I guess."

Not her coolest moment, but she’s also not quite sure what she’s supposed to do here.

Adora looks a little bit shaken, but she recovers well enough, biting the inside of her cheek before she quickly looks around. “Time for bed? I think we could all use a rest.”

“Yeah, okay,” Catra agrees, making her way forward, brow furrowing slightly as Adora gets under the blanket and holds it up for some reason, like she wants someone to get in with her. She said that she wanted to share a bed like they used to though, so Catra curls up at the foot of the bed, ignoring the panging of her heart.

“What…..what are you doing?”

“I…..” Catra stutters, because even if it’s shitty of Adora to say she doesn’t want her here when she’s already in bed, she gets it. “I can go to a different room.”

“No! No, that's not what I mean!” Adora practically yelps, sitting up straight with Catra just barely avoiding a swift kick to the back. “I just meant….why are you down there?”

“You said you wanted to share a bed. Like we used to.”

"That's…..that's not what I meant," Adora frowns, biting the inside of her cheek again. "Not completely like we used to. I want you up here. With me. If you want to."

She sounds so unsure of herself, and Catra hates that she caused that, but she also can't stop her heart from fluttering. "Yeah, okay."

So she finds herself laying in bed next to Adora, on her back and stiff as a board.

"Are…..you don't have to sleep here with me if you don't want to?"

Catra sighs, letting out an "I'm okay" before she tries to situate herself, ignoring the hammering of her heart and the feeling that this is all going to fall apart.

She thinks she can do that, at least for one night.

"We'll talk more? In the morning?" Adora asks, because goddamnit, she can still read Catra after all this time. She also looks happy though, cuddled into Catra's side, and Catra can't help but relax slightly at that.

"Yeah Adora. We can talk."

And with that, Catra pulls Adora into her side, closes her eyes, and lets herself take it all in.

End Notes

Another fic that was sitting half-finished on my desktop, which I finally put the finishing touches on. Hope you liked it!

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!